

The Asian Flavor *Substitution* Cheat Sheet

Forty-seven ingredient swaps across East, Southeast, and South Asian pantries — each with the ratio and what you lose in the trade. Print it. Tape it inside a cabinet door. Stop guessing.

SALT & UMAMI BACKBONE

01 · Fish sauce → soy sauce + a drop of rice vinegar
Approximates salt + umami + acid; loses the oceanic funk. Use 3:4 volume.

02 · Light soy sauce → tamari (reduce 15%)
Tamari is deeper and usually saltier; thin with a splash of water.

03 · Dark soy sauce → light soy + ¼ tsp molasses per tbsp
Molasses restores the color and faint bitterness; don't over-salt.

04 · Shrimp paste (belacan) → fish sauce, halved
Less solid punch; increase 50% if it was a primary flavor.

05 · Oyster sauce → hoisin + soy (2:1) + pinch sugar
Vegan swap: mushroom "oyster" sauce is nearly identical.

06 · White miso → red miso, halved + pinch sugar
Red is saltier and more aggressive; cut the amount, add sweetness.

07 · Doenjang → red miso + ½ tsp fish sauce
Korean soybean paste is funkier; the fish sauce bridges the gap.

08 · Kombu (for dashi) → dried shiitake stems
Different glutamate source; steep cold for the cleanest result.

09 · Katsuobushi → dried anchovies (niboshi), halved
Stronger and fishier; strain early to avoid bitterness.

10 · MSG → grated Parmigiano rind or a splash of soy
All three are free-glutamate delivery; season to taste, not by rule.

FERMENTED CHILI & PASTE

11 · Doubanjiang → gochujang + white miso (1:1)
Fermented chili-bean base; add a pinch of salt — gochujang is sweeter.

12 · Gochujang → sriracha + white miso + ½ tsp sugar
Rebuilds the sweet-fermented-spicy triangle; thicken with tomato paste.

13 · Sambal oelek → crushed red pepper + rice vinegar + salt
Bright raw-chili heat; blend to a coarse paste, don't cook the vinegar off.

14 · Thai red curry paste → red chili + garlic + ginger + lemongrass + shrimp paste
The DIY route beats any single swap; galangal if you have it.

15 · Gochugaru → Aleppo pepper or mild chili flake + paprika
Match the fruity-mild profile, not raw heat; avoid smoky paprika.

16 · Chili crisp → fried garlic + chili flake in hot neutral oil
Bloom the aromatics off-heat; add a pinch of sugar and salt.

17 · Kecap manis → soy sauce + brown sugar (3:1)
Reduce 20% — the sugar caramelizes faster than the original.

ACID & BRIGHTNESS

18 · Rice vinegar → white wine vinegar, cut 25% with water
Rice vinegar is milder and slightly sweet; add a pinch of sugar.

19 · Black vinegar (Chinkiang) → balsamic + rice vinegar (1:1)
Balsamic alone is too sweet; the rice vinegar sharpens it.

20 · Tamarind paste → lime juice + brown sugar
1 tbsp tamarind ≈ 1 tsp lime + ½ tsp sugar. Sour-sweet, not floral.

21 · Yuzu juice → lime + grapefruit + mandarin (2:1:1)
No single citrus matches it; the blend gets you close.

22 · Kalamansi → lime + a squeeze of mandarin
Sweeter and more fragrant than lime alone; adjust to taste.

23 · Ponzu → soy + lemon + rice vinegar + pinch sugar
Citrus-soy; a flake of dashi or bonito deepens it.

24 · Ume plum vinegar → rice vinegar + extra salt + drop of lemon
Umeboshi brine is intensely salty-sour; go light.

SWEET & COOKING WINE

25 · Mirin → dry sherry + 1 tsp sugar per tbsp
Sake + sugar is closer if you have it; skip "cooking mirin" — it's salted.

26 · Sake (for cooking) → dry vermouth or dry white wine
Both add acidity and lift; Chinese Shaoxing is closer in character.

27 · Shaoxing wine → dry sherry (not "cooking sherry")
The nuttiness matches; dry pale sherry over cream sherry.

28 · Palm sugar → brown sugar + a drop of molasses
Coconut sugar is the closest 1:1; brown sugar is fine in a pinch.

29 · Rock sugar → granulated sugar, same weight
Rock sugar is gentler and glossier; dissolve fully before judging.

AROMATICS & HERBS

30 · Galangal → ginger + pinch black pepper
Ginger is warmer, less piney; functional in most curries, not identical.

31 · Lemongrass → lemon zest + a sliver of ginger
1 stalk ≈ 1 tsp zest; you lose the grassy floral top note.

32 · Kaffir lime leaf → lime zest + bay leaf
Nothing truly replaces it; zest carries most of the aroma.

33 · Thai basil → Italian basil + a pinch of mint + fennel seed
Rebuilds the anise edge Italian basil lacks.

34 · Curry leaves → no true swap — omit + a pinch of ground fenugreek
Don't substitute basil or bay; better to leave out than mislead.

35 · Thai bird's eye chili → serrano, doubled
Less heat, similar brightness; add cayenne to push the burn.

36 · Fresh turmeric → ground turmeric (1 tsp ≈ 1 in root)
Add early so the raw powder taste cooks out.

37 · Coconut cream → **chilled full-fat coconut milk, top layer only**
Same product — the fat separates cold; scoop the solid cap.

38 · Coconut milk → **coconut cream + water (2:3)**
Or whole milk + ½ tsp coconut extract for a lighter dish.

39 · Ghee → **clarified butter, or butter + neutral oil**
The oil raises the smoke point; you lose a little nuttiness.

40 · Toasted sesame oil → **tahini thinned with neutral oil**
Finish off-heat; toasted sesame aroma is fragile and fat-soluble.

41 · Tapioca / potato starch → **cornstarch, ¾ the amount**
Cornstarch clouds and sets firmer; slurry it cold.

42 · Sichuan peppercorn → **black pepper + coriander + tiny lemon zest**
You cannot fake the tingle (málà); this fakes the citrus-pine aroma.

43 · Five-spice → **cinnamon + clove + fennel + star anise + pepper**
Equal parts, ground fresh; star anise is the non-negotiable one.

44 · Garam masala → **cumin + coriander + cardamom + cinnamon + clove**
Toast whole, then grind; add at the end, not the start.

45 · Furikake → **toasted sesame + crumbled nori + salt + pinch sugar**
A dusting of bonito powder makes it near-exact.

46 · Pickled ginger (gari) → **fresh ginger in rice vinegar + sugar, 20 min**
Slice paper-thin; a pinch of salt draws out the sharpness first.

47 · Nori → **toasted dulse or a pinch of kombu powder**
For flavor, not wrapping; both bring the same marine glutamate.